ened since Modi took charge in 2014 and 51 per cent don't expect the situation to get better in the next six months. Moreover, more than half of those surveyed expect their household income to stagnate or even worsen, with 64 per cent indicating that their income had declined because of Covid-19. Some 45 per cent also described the shortage of jobs as an extremely serious problem. These should be red flags for the Modi government.

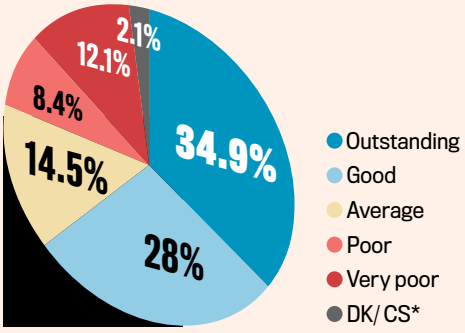
The poll findings also explain why despite the higher rating in overall performance of both the prime minister and his government, as compared to the previous poll, their position in terms of a majority in the 543-member Lok Sabha remains tenuous when compared to their big win in 2019. While there is no immediate danger to the stability of the government, if an election was held now, the NDA would be down to 296 seats from the actual 352 it won in May 2019—a loss of 56 seats. For the second consecutive MOTN survey, the ruling BJP shows a drop of over 30 seats, with its individual tally down to 271 seats—one short of a majority—compared to the 303 seats it actually won in the 2019 election. The Congress party has gained, but not by much, adding only 10 seats to its tally of 52 in 2019.

WHILE BENEFICIARIES MAY LAUD THE PM FOR HIS MANY WELFARE SCHEMES, THEY WOULD RATHER HAVE **SECURE EMPLOYMENT AND INCOME THAN LIVE ON GOVT DOLES**

The situation could have been far worse for the BJP had the Congress position in the key states where it won assembly elections in 2018—Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh—not weakened considerably. The current MOTN survey suggests that the BJP would win a majority in these states today, as it did in 2019. Even in Gujarat, where the Congress put up a good fight in the 2017 assembly poll, it is unlikely to make any gains in parliamentary polls as things stand, thanks to subsequent infighting in the party. Conversely, the BJP will have to rely on winning these four states along with a big sweep in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar to retain its majority. The MOTN poll shows that the BJP's major push for seats in the east and the south have not borne as much fruit. The party suffered a grievous defeat in the West Bengal state election last year and, in Odisha, Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik remains invincible. The BJP's position in Karnataka remains fragile while in Telangana, the BJP is unlikely to unseat the K. Chandrashekar Rao government despite making big strides. Nor has it been able to shake the hold of the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi coalition in Maharashtra.

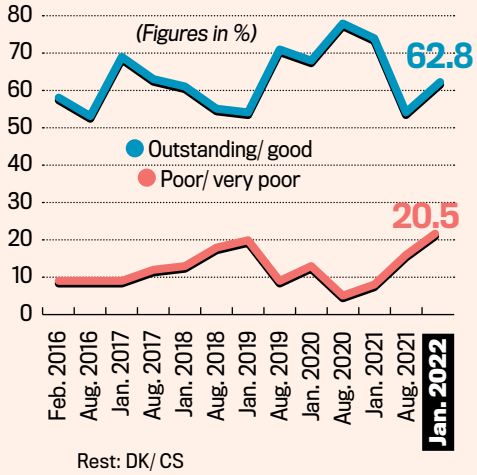
However, while Modi's charisma may be yielding diminishing returns in recent state elections, he continues to be the BJP's

Q. HOW DO YOU RATE THE PERFORMANCE OF NARENDRA MODI AS PRIME MINISTER?



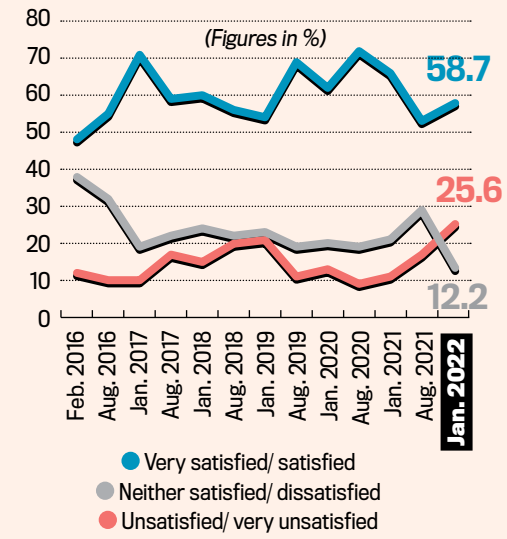
DK/ CS: Don't know/ can't say

MODI'S PERFORMANCE OVER THE YEARS



Rest: DK/ CS

Q. HOW SATISFIED ARE YOU WITH THE OVERALL PERFORMANCE OF THE NDA GOVERNMENT?



Rest: DK/ CS